

KF20 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we will be learning about the self-hate experience. You might think that your enemy is self-hate, but that is not true. Your real enemy is the Idol Self. Self-hate is simply the result of living in the Idol’s system. When you fail to meet your idealized standards, the Idol uses self-hate to drive you into compulsive choices and then punishes you with more self-hate for having made those choices. Over the last few weeks, we have been retraining our minds and learning to value our real or imagined failures as opportunities for growth. We have also been exploring tools that help us deal with the associated feelings, motivations, and behaviors of self-hate. The training isn’t easy, but we are training hard so that we can fight easy for the life of our True Self. Even in the midst of self-hate we can connect to God and make oriented choices.

Research has proven the many positive benefits of meditation and mindfulness practice.¹ One of those benefits is the ability to recognize self-hate. Mindfulness training helps us pause, step back, and observe rather than react. The ability to step back gives us the breathing space that we often need to make a healthier choice.

The Self-Hate Massage

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Bring to mind an area of your life that chronically stirs up self-hate for you. Perhaps you have made some mistakes, or perhaps your limitations have prevented you from achieving something. You might dislike your physical body, or you might wish that you were someone else. Let’s connect that hurt to our breathing and get acquainted with it using our new tools. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

CONSIDER

Take a moment to collect yourself within your present space. Feel the air or the clothing on your skin. Notice any noises. *(Pause for 30 seconds)* Now consider this area of self-hate. Notice the discomfort you feel when you think of it. Even though you hate this thing, gently and without judgment allow it to rest inside your skin for one minute. Breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

COMPASSION

As you breathe, experience yourself as a creature with limitations breathing in a material world. *(Pause)* You are not a god. *(Pause)* As you breathe in and out, imagine your area of self-hate moving in and out with the breath, massaging this place in your soul that is stuck or cramped. For one minute, help that area of self-hate circulate in and out with the breath. Give it and receive it with compassion. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

CLEANSE

Notice your entire body as it breathes. *(Pause)* Breathe with your mind, body, and soul as you open the doors of the prison cells of your shame, regrets, pain, and guilt. *(Pause)* Allow the clean air to sweep through those dark, stagnant places for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our hymn for this confession is *My Faith Looks Up to Thee*.

May Thy rich grace impart
Strength to my fainting heart,
My zeal inspire;
As Thou hast died for me,
Oh, may my love to Thee
Pure, warm, and changeless be,
A living fire.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 5:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

One morning, when I was on the brink of waking up and still half-asleep, I began playing in my head a conversation between imaginary people. Although I can't recall what the conversation was about or who was involved, I do remember that I immediately and mindfully recognized that I was wasting my energy on a fantasy and then chose to withdraw my mind from the imaginary conversation. Withdrawing my mind was a rational move, but I was not prepared for the rush of self-hate and guilt that I felt for having done so. I felt as if I had snubbed real people. I know that's kind of crazy, but I wasn't surprised at my feelings because, as a self-effacing type, I need to feel loving and attentive to everyone—even imaginary people! I have learned that self-hate is crazy; it's not rational. But even though self-hate is irrational, it can become our friend. It helps us identify our Idol's compulsive needs.

You might consider these five points about self-hate:

1. Our job is to grow out of our self-hate

This month we will begin looking at how self-hate operates in our lives. New areas of self-hate will continue to be revealed as we go through life, but now we can choose how we deal with that self-hate. We can either appease it by sacrificing our True Self and submitting to the demands of the Idol, or we can grow out of it. I hope that in the last few months you have worked at developing the endurance and courage that it takes to grow out of self-hate.

2. Train hard—fight easy

When we experience self-hate, we often don't know what we are experiencing. We just suddenly feel the need to run back to old feelings, stories, and behaviors that have made us feel safe or comfortable in the past. That feels crazy sometimes, and we may even think that we are crazy. Actually, self-hate is crazy, and without training we won't be able to deal with it. This is why it is imperative that we train hard. Self-hate is like a ninja sneaking around in your compound, creating havoc and always ready to stick a knife in your back. We aren't always aware of its presence, but we see the effects of self-hate in our relationships, in our work, and in our own consciousness. Sometimes self-hate is like a raging bull in a china shop—a wild animal driven out of control by fear. When we are in self-hate, we smash even what we love. If you have not been training hard, you will do damage before you can stop yourself, and when you come to your senses, you will find yourself standing in a lot of broken china. It's not your goal as a citizen of God's kingdom to repeatedly cause harm and create chaos. Your goal is to produce the Fruit of the Spirit in every situation, and with that goal in mind you must train hard so that you can fight self-hate easy.³

3. Calm the fear through mindfulness training

Over the years we have learned to fear self-hate and the ravaging chaos it creates. What's more, we have developed automatic and habitual patterns of thought and behavior that we hope will enable us to avoid our self-hate. Rather than reverting to these habitual patterns, we can use mindfulness to calm our minds and bodies. We are then free to choose healthy patterns of thought and behavior that help us grow out of our self-hate. We want to become people of no fear who are motivated by love. That doesn't mean that we will never experience fear. God designed us to feel fear for our protection, but we are not to be driven or mastered by our fear. Our only master is the Lord.

Just as mindfulness training helps us refocus our wandering minds during meditation, it empowers us to redirect our thinking when the Idol has us by the throat and is lashing us with self-hate. When we recognize the symptoms of self-hate, we can choose to simply wait and mindfully endure our chaotic feelings until we are able to figure out what's going on. We learn that we do not have to react. Instead, we can compassionately observe, listen, and learn.

Writing the lessons for this confession was very difficult for me because for most of my life I had been paralyzed by self-hate. I felt terrified and wanted to go into paralysis and procrastination to affirm my compulsive need to feel inadequate and a disappointment both to myself and to others. I wrote for a whole week and was unable to find my path.

4. Self-hate can actually strengthen our endurance

Self-hate has the power to stop us in our tracks, so how was I able to write this lesson? I had been in training through the book study and through meditation practice. Dr. Horney's book had taught me how the Idol Self scourges me with self-hate when I do not meet its expectations. Based on that information, I was able to recognize the source of my self-hate. I persevered in my work despite my discomfort, working against the resistance of my fear. This work-out strengthened my courage and trained me to skillfully endure and choose healthy and productive behaviors no matter how I felt. The

week of writing and getting nowhere actually led me somewhere. I learned to be productive in the midst of my self-hate, knowing that God would support me if I humbly endured my discomforts.

5. The un-lived life is not worth examining

Socrates, the ancient Greek philosopher, said that *the unexamined life is not worth living*,⁴ but some writers turn that quotation around and assert that *the un-lived life is not worth examining*. (Repeat) We have lived in a state of perpetual flight from self-hate for so long that flight feels natural to us. Running away may help us feel less tension in the moment, but that choice is compulsive rather than free and does not express the glory of God. Running away results in an un-lived life. The examination of such a life might awaken a little pity, but it will also be extremely boring.

Flight from self-hate looks different for different Idol types. Some will run away by controlling or abusing themselves or others; some fly by appeasing and pleasing; and then there are those who flee by taking refuge in their fortress of non-engagement. All neurotic flight is self-sabotage. Think of any good story. It's the discovery of the hero's character, how he or she grows and responds to life, that grips our interest and helps us relate to the hero. But what if the story was a constant series of "This scary thing happened, and he ran away. And then this other painful thing happened, and she ran away. And then there was this incredible opportunity and . . ." By now we can finish the story for ourselves—we ran away.

With training, you can learn to stand without running away. You can mindfully stay inside your skin as the wave of self-hate rushes over you and eventually exhausts itself on the shore.

You can look for examples of self-hate in chapters 12–16 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*.⁵ Review the chapter on self-hate and the chapter that describes your neurotic development. Make a list of those things that stir up self-hate for you. Once you have identified your self-hate hotspots, take ownership of them and then—train hard, fight easy.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Captain of the hosts, train me to stand. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 5 describes the path of wasted energy and lost potential:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

Let's look at **Psalm 23:1–4**. I offer here a valid alternative translation using familiar KF vocabulary.

¹The Lord is my Shepherd,
I have everything that I need today.

²He makes me lie down satisfied in green pastures;
 He leads me beside quiet waters.
³For His own reputation and for my reputation as His creature,
 He restores and repairs my True Self.
⁴He guides me in the tracks of orientation even though
 I walk through the valley of the shadow of death.
 I fear no harm, for You are with me.
 The guidance and training of Your rod and staff comfort me.

Take a deep breath.

1. Our Shepherd is the Lord, not our Idol Self

Our relationship with the Shepherd is not a legal contract based on shoulds, claims, and punishments. It is based on the trust and the trustworthiness that is developed in a karis relationship. The Shepherd takes into consideration your unique personhood as He guides you; He responds to what you reveal about yourself. He is the one who trains you for your joy and for your mission. By doing things His way, you grow into your purpose and glory, and you declare His purposes and glory. You enjoy the security and care of a real Shepherd and are no longer the victim of the untrustworthy hireling, the Idol Self.⁶

2. I have everything that I need for today

With Jesus as our Shepherd, and not the Idol Self, we can gradually let go of fighting for our idealized life, fleeing self-hate, and trying to get our compulsive needs met. As we spend time doing things His way, we begin to experience satisfaction and contentment.

One of the things that we need when we are in self-hate is a quiet, safe place. When you are with someone who is suffering from self-hate, my advice is this: *No sudden movements. No loud noises. (Repeat)* What I mean is this: be compassionate around those in self-hate, including yourself—and be very careful. You can see that they are not in their right minds, so don't try to force them. They have been trapped by the Idol Self, the hunter.⁷ Self-hate makes people reactive, touchy, anxious, and volatile, so you must approach them as you would approach a raging bull or a frightened wild animal—quietly, gently, safely, restfully, patiently, and with firm boundaries. The Lord does the same for you. He knows that when you are in self-hate, you need to be quiet and feel safe so that you can get back into your own skin.

3. He restores my True Self, not my Idol Self

In order to restore our lost True Self, we need to calm down, follow the Shepherd's leading, and find rest. The Hebrew word for *restore* can be translated as *turning back*. This word also carries the meaning of *recovery*—finding something that was left behind—and the meaning of *repair*. Does your soul need repair? The soul that Jesus died for and repairs is our True Self, not the Idol. Sometimes we feel very disappointed about that. We often would prefer that He support our Idol Self, but He cannot do that. How could the Lord of glory, the God of love and truth, do that? I wonder if you will cooperate with Jesus. Jesus can't repair your soul by Himself, however. He needs your cooperation. It's your soul, after all.

4. He guides me in the tracks of orientation for His name's sake

If we call ourselves Christians, we bear the name of Jesus, and we are responsible for His reputation. As oriented people, we are the representatives of His name and character in this messed-up world.

Sometimes we get caught up in representing a way of thinking or an organization. That is not our real business. Our business is to be oriented to God and represent His kingdom. The world can only know Jesus if our lives express who He is. With our cooperation, Jesus gently guides us to gradually walk in His tracks, the tracks of orientation; we learn to make His footsteps our pathway.⁸

When we walk in the paths of orientation, we benefit from His provision, and the evidence of His generous and faithful care enhances His name, or reputation, in this poverty-stricken world.

5. The tracks of orientation lead into the valley of the shadow of death

To our dismay, the tracks of orientation always lead into the valley of the shadow of death. It will feel like death to give up old patterns and behaviors that you have habitually used to save your Idol's life. We are in Karis Fellowships because we want a different life, but in order to gain that different life, we have to lose the Idol's life.⁹ The Psalmist says: *He guides me in the tracks of orientation even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death.* When we begin to follow the tracks toward orientation and confront our self-hate, it feels like death. We imagine that our survival is threatened, and we feel the terror of shame, humiliation, deprivation, and the loss of control. We have spent the whole of our lives in bondage, or slavery, to the fear of death. Since our early childhood, that fear has motivated us to do whatever we think will save our lives. Fear feels so compelling, but now I am telling you to challenge it. How do I have the courage to tell you to do that? Because I believe what the Bible teaches me about fear, and the evidence of my own life proves that the Bible is a faithful and trustworthy guide. The fear of death is only a shadow for Christians. It is the darkness that we enter when we dare to resist the Idol Self and its pride system. The fear of death is real, but it moves on like a cloud passing over the sun. It only has the power of a shadow.

6. His rod and staff comfort me

The rod and staff are instruments of training—the *do's* and *don'ts* of the Bible. They replace the shoulds and claims of your own legal systems. You can trust the rod and staff in the Shepherd's hands as He trains you for your potential. When you commit to doing things God's way, you have to stop doing things your way. That feels like losing your life. When you realize that you cannot depend on your legal systems to motivate you, you feel lost and full of self-hate. You want to judge yourself and others. You want to kill yourself, or somebody else. You constructed your legal systems to gain ground in your search for glory, and this imagined ground is difficult to give up. You might think: *If I stop chasing my tail, I'll lose all the ground that I've gained!*¹⁰ (Repeat) Chasing your Idol's tail makes you feel busy, but you get nowhere. Hopefully, you are ready to learn another way to live. Any place of transition is very uncomfortable, and to endure that discomfort you will need every bit of the strength that you have gained through mindfulness and meditation training.

Lots of people get to this place in their KF work and quit. But when you want to abandon the path toward orientation and avoid this difficult process of training, the promise of God's presence and His faithful provision can help you keep going. If you choose to persevere, you will discover your True Self and enjoy the rewards of real self-confidence. You will live in the hope that comes from productive personal experience. Ask, seek, knock, and let God open the doors. Stop chasing the Idol's tail. Work toward becoming a loving person rather than someone who feels entitled to be unconditionally loved, invariably accommodated, and totally unhindered. As you persevere in your training and explore your true design, you will experience God as your ally and the Creation as your partner in this material world.¹¹ You will become rich enough to circulate your many gifts. You will experience increasing enthusiasm and joy—and much less strain.

I knew a woman who had debilitating health issues, a ruined appearance, chronic and paralyzing anxiety, learning disabilities, and a challenging marriage. She had experienced a difficult childhood and felt ashamed of who she was and what she did. She carried all that hurt with her when she moved to a very discouraging location. For years, she had begged the Lord to relieve her suffering, and now it seemed that more suffering had been added to her load. Soon after the move, however, she was reading the Bible and suddenly the Holy Spirit spoke to her these words of encouragement: “I will now give you peace from all your adversaries and you will build a temple to the glory of the Name.”¹² Today, the Lord has fulfilled His promise and she is building that temple. Look at the rest of Psalm 23. King David writes about his adversaries, or enemies, and how he co-labored with God to overcome them. What do your enemies look like?

During this coming week, think about how this psalm supports your efforts toward orientation. You might print out the psalm and post it where you will see it every day. Read back over these notes. Psalm 23 encourages us to grow in our courage while we confront the problem of our pride, self-hate, and judgments. With the comforting guidance and protection of the Shepherd’s rod and staff, you too can journey productively through any problem.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Shepherd, strengthen my courage and endurance for the valley. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider something in your life that feels like the valley of the shadow of death. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from this section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

How does it feel to stand on the edge of the valley of the shadow of death? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness as you *consider this situation that feels like the valley of the shadow of death*. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling. *(Pause)* Give yourself permission now to explore your feelings and thoughts without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you consider this situation. What

sensations are there? (Pause) If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this situation that feels like the valley of the shadow of death*. Do you feel compelled to judge that valley as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe about this valley? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* How might your Idol's pride be hurt if you were to step into this valley? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered a valley that feels like death*. You are human and not alone in your experience. In the Bible we read of many people who have walked through dark valleys. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body, and that chemistry is often created by your past experiences.¹³ Just acknowledging your feelings can help you understand yourself. When feelings bring you information, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* We must each contend with our own valleys, so breathe and allow some compassion to flow toward yourself and toward others. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 15 seconds)*

Allow your feelings to inform you but not motivate you. Apply your training, consider what is your business, and make oriented choices as you enter your valley. *(Pause for 15 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for the gift of healing and training together. Help us find courage in Your promises as You guide us to access Your provision. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to pass through the valley of the shadow of death so that we can flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ www.healthline.com/nutrition/12-benefits-of-meditation#section13.

² *My Faith Looks Up to Thee* by Ray Palmer (1808–1887), youtu.be/X5g-Att0bmE.

³ Gal. 5:1–26.

⁴ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_unexamined_life_is_not_worth_living.

⁵ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁶ John 10:11–13.

⁷ See KF12.

⁸ Psalm 85:13.

⁹ Matt. 10:39.

¹⁰ Quote from Bob Diven, www.bobdiven.com/home.html.

¹¹ Rom. 8:22–24.

¹² 1 Kings 5:3–5.

¹³ [en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Candace Pert](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Candace_Pert).